Lekshmi Radhakrishnan

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

I am interested in how the interpretive frames people inherit shape the way psychological distress is expressed and recognized, where that produces misclassification, and who ends up without care. When clinician and patient do not share a frame, error can run in both directions: what is culturally ordinary is pathologized, and genuine illness expressed in unfamiliar terms is missed. The pattern is well documented in psychotic-spectrum illness, where racial and ethnic disparities in diagnosis and treatment are established. I treat this as a matter of measurement validity rather than cultural sensitivity, and I am particularly concerned with whether measures of distress retain the same meaning across groups. My training so far spans several levels of the problem: clinical research on perinatal anxiety and obsessive-compulsive conditions, the cultural evolution of belief and moral judgment, neuroimaging and comparative neuroscience of social bonding, and health-services research on barriers to psychiatric care. These questions began in a psychiatric residential facility I managed for two years, where most residents had chronic psychotic disorders and many were immigrants.

EDUCATION

Harvard University, Extension School — Cambridge, MA **2024 – Present**
Master of Liberal Arts (ALM), Psychology · GPA: 3.9/4.0 · Expected 2027

- **Master's thesis (in progress)** · Advisor: Richard J. McNally, PhD.
- **Graduate coursework:** Cognitive Neuroscience (Elizabeth Phelps) · Markers of Psychopathology · Introduction to Medical Neuroscience · Dogs: Behavior and Evolution (Erin Hecht) · Proseminar in Graduate Study
- **Statistics sequence:** Introduction to Quantitative Methods · Introduction to Statistical Modeling · Statistics: Methods and Modeling
- **Additional coursework:** Psychology of Diversity (Mona Weissmark) · Race in a Polarized America (Jennifer Hochschild) · Deliberative Justice
- **Audited coursework:** Primate Social Behavior; The *Pan* Model for Human Evolution — Martin Surbeck, PhD, Department of Human Evolutionary Biology (Fall 2025)
- **Course research projects:** an interview study of ethnic identity in older and younger Indian American men using the MEIM-R (Psychology of Diversity, 2022); and a co-designed interview study of whether moving into or out of the American South changes perspectives on structural racism (Race in a Polarized America, 2023).

Thomas Edison State University — Trenton, NJ
Bachelor of Arts, Liberal Studies · GPA: 4.0/4.0

- **Capstone:** *Unraveling Gender Disparity: Analyzing the Absence of a Woman President in America* · Advisor: Catherine Peck, PhD. A study of the cultural, structural, and knowledge barriers to women's political leadership in the United States, drawing on ambivalent sexism, system justification theory, and social role theory.

Wichita State University — Wichita, KS
Post-baccalaureate coursework in psychology

University of Kerala — Kerala, India
Bachelor of Arts, Psychology

- Coursework in experimental, developmental, abnormal, and industrial psychology.

HONORS & ACADEMIC DISTINCTIONS

- **Psi Chi**, International Honor Society in Psychology — elected member, Wichita State University chapter
- **Dean's Honor Roll** — Wichita State University
- **President's List** — Thomas Edison State University

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

Conrad, R. C., Koire, A., **Radhakrishnan, L.**, Charroux, A., Klingler, S., Benson, N. M., & Boyd, J. W. (2025). Impact of state medical licensure exemptions and telehealth registries on college students' access to psychiatric care. *Psychiatric Services, 76*(6), 602–605. https://doi.org/10.1176/appi.ps.20240225

Media Coverage

Many psychiatrists unaware of out-of-state exemptions for patients—or unwilling to use them. Psychiatric News Alert (February 10, 2025). Coverage of Conrad et al. (2025). https://alert.psychnews.org/2025/02/many-psychiatrists-unaware-of-out-of.html

Manuscripts Under Review

Hecht, E. E., Rogers Flattery, C., Abdulla, M., Michlich, J., **Radhakrishnan, L.**, Dooyema, J., Chavez Flores, A., Swardstrom, R., Rogers, F., Helen, J., Althammer, F., Kukekova, A. V., & Sherwood, C. C. (2026). Hypothalamic oxytocin and vasopressin cell populations do not differ across selectively-bred silver fox lineages but covary with brain-wide structural organization. *Journal of Comparative Neurology* (minor revision submitted September 2026).

Manuscripts in Preparation

Cross-lagged panel network analysis of ecological momentary assessment data on obsessive-compulsive symptoms in the perinatal period. Coauthor; author order to be determined.

INVITED PRESENTATIONS & POLICY BRIEFINGS

Radhakrishnan, L. & Conrad, R. C. (2023, July–August). *Interstate licensure barriers to college students' access to psychiatric care.* Series of invited briefings on study findings, co-presented at each, to regulators, health-policy organizations, insurers, and academic and legal experts — including the Federation of State Medical Boards (Humayun Chaudhry, President and CEO); the Massachusetts Board of Registration in Medicine; the American Medical Association; the American Telemedicine Association; the Commonwealth Fund; the Kennedy Forum; the ERISA Industry Committee; Connect With Care; the Center for Connected Health Policy; Blue Cross Blue Shield of Massachusetts (Vice President for Government and Regulatory Affairs); and faculty at Harvard Medical School, Harvard Law School, Northeastern University School of Law, and the University of Arizona College of Law.

- Briefings informed draft federal telehealth policy recommendations developed with the Kennedy Forum and model telehealth language circulated by the ERISA Industry Committee.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Thesis Student and Research Assistant — Department of Psychology, Harvard University **2026 – Present**
Thesis Advisor and Principal Investigator: Richard J. McNally, PhD

- **Perinatal HEART:** prospective study of perinatal trauma risk combining heart rate variability and ecological momentary assessment (EMA) from pregnancy through the postpartum period (IRB protocol submitted October 2026). Drafted the participant pre-screener, translating the protocol's eligibility criteria into screening items and branching logic, and implemented it in Qualtrics; built the recruitment tracker and assembled study measures and scoring materials.
- **Perinatal OCD:** coauthor on a manuscript in preparation applying cross-lagged panel network analysis to EMA data on perinatal obsessive-compulsive symptoms.
- **Obsessive beliefs review:** screened studies and extracted data for a systematic review of associations between obsessive beliefs and specific OCD symptom dimensions.
- Contribute to IRB protocols and informed consent documents; assembling the study's regulatory binder; develop psychoeducational resources for participants.

Research Assistant — Department of Psychology, Harvard University **Sept. 2026 – Present**
Principal Investigator: Joshua Conrad Jackson, PhD · Cultural Dynamics Lab

- **Religion:** contribute to a project using an ethnographic database of supernatural agents to study the cultural evolution of religious belief; developing LLM-assisted coding of ethnographic texts, validated against human coders.
- **Norms:** contribute to a multi-country survey study of everyday social norms and how they are enforced.

Independent Research Proposal — Harvard University **2025 – Present**
Can Learning About Bonobo Female Leadership Reduce Gender Stereotypes in Humans?

- Proposed a study testing whether short educational videos and lessons about female coalitions and leadership in bonobos shift implicit and explicit gender stereotypes, by challenging narratives that present male dominance as the natural order.
- Authored the literature review, situating the intervention across primatology, gender-role theory, and research on counterstereotypical role models.

- Conceived independently and developed in consultation with faculty in primatology, evolutionary neuroscience, and affective neuroscience.

Laboratory Assistant — ASPR Paleo Lab, Peabody Museum, Harvard University **2026**
- Curated and systematically logged Siwalik fossil specimens; supported the collection's repatriation to Pakistan, and researched conservation and packing materials so the fossils remain stable through prolonged storage after arrival.

Research Affiliate — Surbeck Lab (Pan Lab), Human Evolutionary Biology, Harvard University **2025 – 2026**
Principal Investigator: Martin Surbeck, PhD
- Cleaned and organized existing GPS ranging data from bonobo field research to prepare it for spatial analysis.
- Participated in weekly Pan Lab meetings and the Pan Seminar series on bonobo and chimpanzee social behavior, cognition, and cultural evolution.

Research Assistant — Department of Human Evolutionary Biology, Harvard University **2024 – 2026**
Principal Investigator: Erin E. Hecht, PhD · Evolutionary Neuroscience Lab & Canine Brains Project
- Acquired human and canine MRI data (MRI safety certified, Yellow Badge), including pediatric neuroimaging and mock-scanner desensitization training in collaboration with the Gaab Lab (CALC study).
- Collected and processed behavioral and neuroimaging data from pediatric participants (ages 7–12) in a study of the human–canine bond.
- Performed stereological quantification of oxytocin- and vasopressin-producing neurons in the supraoptic and paraventricular hypothalamic nuclei of tame, aggressive, and unselected silver fox lineages (Russian farm-fox experiment; n = 18), using immunohistochemistry and unbiased sampling methods.
- Took over the cell-counting project, coordinated the remaining counters, and brought the dataset to a publishable endpoint (resubmitted after minor revision; fifth of thirteen authors).
- Administered canine behavior testing protocols and coded behavioral video data for cross-species cognition and social-bonding studies.
- Led participant recruitment and family communication, coordinating longitudinal study schedules and ensuring protocol adherence and data integrity.

Research Assistant — Center for Bioethics, Harvard Medical School **2023 – 2024**
Principal Investigator: Rachel C. Conrad, MD
- Co-authored a peer-reviewed study in Psychiatric Services (third author) quantifying how state licensure exemptions and telehealth registries shape college students' access to psychiatric care.
- Refined the initial design of, and executed, a multi-state "secret shopper" study assessing real-world availability of cross-state telepsychiatry for students, working closely with the PI across all phases.
- Translated findings into policy recommendations and co-presented them to regulators, health-policy organizations, and legal experts; independently met with a Washington state representative in Olympia and contacted legislative offices in Washington and Massachusetts to share the findings.

Research Assistant — Science of Diversity Lab, Harvard University **2022 – 2023**
Principal Investigator: Mona Weissmark, PhD
- Supported editorial preparation of *Seeing the Other Side: Shifting Perceptions*, a scholarly treatment of intergroup perspective-taking, transgenerational trauma, and the psychology of cultural and racial difference.
- Conducted fact-checking and reference verification across the manuscript.

CLINICAL & APPLIED MENTAL HEALTH EXPERIENCE

Team Leader — Psychiatric Assisted Living Facility **2 years**
Mental Health Association of South Central Kansas — Wichita, KS
- Managed a residential psychiatric facility serving 30+ adults with chronic psychiatric conditions, predominantly psychotic-spectrum disorders, including schizophrenia with prominent paranoid features.
- Conducted functional assessments and formal intake and treatment-plan reviews; designed and revised individualized care plans.
- Delivered crisis intervention and day-to-day behavioral support, and coached residents on the daily living skills needed for independent community living.
- Maintained clinical documentation: patient records, treatment plans, daily progress notes, and service reports.
- Trained and supervised staff on regulatory compliance and state mental health standards.
- Supported a substantial immigrant and non-English-speaking resident population, adapting care planning and daily communication across language and cultural difference.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant — HEB 140: Evolution of Friendship **2025 – 2026**
Department of Human Evolutionary Biology, Harvard University · Head Instructor: Jennifer Devereaux, PhD

- Delivered lectures and led weekly discussion sections for undergraduate and graduate students on the evolutionary, psychological, cultural, and social dimensions of social bonding.
- Graded research papers and empirical critiques, providing individualized analytic feedback and academic support.
- Collaborated with the head instructor to refine course structure and assignment rubrics.

RESEARCH SKILLS & METHODS

Neuroimaging: MRI data acquisition (MRI safety certified, Yellow Badge); pediatric neuroimaging protocols; mock-scanner desensitization training; structural MRI data organization and quality control (MRIcron).

Laboratory: Immunohistochemistry and stereological quantification of neuropeptide-producing cell populations; fossil specimen curation and cataloging.

Assessment & Measurement: Ecological momentary assessment (EMA), heart rate variability (HRV) collection and processing, behavioral testing protocols, psychometric assessment, structured systematic review and data extraction.

Statistical & Computational: R, Python, C++, Java.

Regulatory & Research Administration: IRB and IACUC protocol preparation and amendment, informed consent procedures, human subjects regulatory compliance, participant recruitment and retention, longitudinal study coordination, family scheduling and communication.

Tools: REDCap, Qualtrics, Git, Zotero, Paperpile.

Cross-Cultural Research: Semi-structured interview design and administration; face-to-face administration of the Multigroup Ethnic Identity Measure–Revised (MEIM-R); interview transcription; community engagement with Adivasi communities in Kerala and South Asian diaspora communities in the U.S.

Languages: English, Malayalam, Tamil, Hindi (fluent) — enabling participant recruitment, interviewing, and data collection in South Asian and diaspora communities without an interpreter.

CERTIFICATIONS & TRAINING

- MRI Safety Certification (Yellow Badge) — Harvard Center for Brain Science Neuroimaging, November 2024
- Certified Youth & Adult Mental Health First Aider — National Council for Mental Wellbeing
- Certificate in Social Justice — Harvard Extension School
- Certificate in Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) Interventions — Stellenbosch University
- CITI Program, Harvard University — Human Subjects Research: Social & Behavioral Investigators (IRB) and Good Clinical Practice, both current through September 2027; Information Privacy and Security (Researchers), current through January 2027

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

- **Association for Behavioral and Cognitive Therapies (ABCT)** — Student Member, 2026 – Present
- **ABCT Special Interest Groups:** Asian American Issues in Behavior Therapy and Research · Psychosis and Schizophrenia Spectrum (PASS) · Clinical Research Methods and Statistics · Dissemination and Implementation Science

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE & LEADERSHIP

Treasurer — Psi Chi, International Honor Society in Psychology, Wichita State University chapter

Board Member — New Guinea Singing Dog Conservation Society **2026 – Present**

Executive Committee Member — Committee on the Concerns of Women at Harvard (CCW) **2025 – Present**

Executive Member — Healthy Youth Initiative Coalition, Mercer Island, WA **2021 – 2024**

- Served on an interdisciplinary coalition of school administrators, mental health professionals, educators, and public safety officials advancing youth mental health, school safety, and equitable education access.

Vice President of Advocacy & Communications — PTA Council, Mercer Island, WA **2020 – 2022**

- Advocated for district- and state-level mental health legislation and resource equity as Legislation Chair, coordinating implementation of national advocacy programs.
- Co-founded and led the Action Committee for Environmental Sustainability (ACES), building community partnerships and district-wide sustainability initiatives.

CROSS-CULTURAL & COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

- **Volunteer Coordinator** — Attappady Hill Area Development Society, Kerala, India. Partnered with Indigenous Adivasi communities on capacity-building and sustainable land management, coordinating local volunteers and securing funding for community-led income-generating initiatives.
- **Board of Directors, Treasurer & Event Coordinator** — Child Rights and You (CRY), Houston, TX. Led awareness campaigns on children's welfare and educational access across both Indian-American and broader U.S. audiences; oversaw financial reporting and strategic performance tracking.
- **Co-Founder** — South Asian Parent Affinity Group, Mercer Island, WA. Built a cultural affinity space to increase visibility and belonging for South Asian families, and convened listening sessions with district leadership on culturally responsive school practice.
- **Volunteer Educator** — Seaside Elementary School, Torrance, CA. Provided K–5 literacy, mathematics, and science instruction at an under-resourced public school; adapted instruction for diverse learning needs and fostered family engagement.
- **Volunteer** — The Friday Café at First Church, Cambridge, MA (2025 – Present), community support for neighbors experiencing homelessness; **Member**, Citizens' Climate Lobby (2023 – Present).